

Example: A troll casts a cantrip and the player rolls six dice, the character's Legerdemain + Fae. The character's Nightmare rating is currently 8, meaning that the player replaces all six of the dice in the pool with distinct Nightmare dice. She does not roll eight dice, because the original dice pool was only six. Nightmare dice replacing normal dice will never increase the total number of dice in the pool, except when a character Unleashes an Art (see Unleashing, page 196).

Nightmare appears below the character's Willpower on the character sheet, and is only tracked as a pool from 0 to 10. Players mark Nightmare from left to right, and incur Nightmare when they botch a Glamour or cantrip roll (adds one Nightmare), Unleash an Art (add one Nightmare before rolling to Unleash), and by rolling 10s on Nightmare dice (+1 Nightmare for each 10 rolled).

Players can reduce the difficulty of a cantrip roll by 1 by replacing another three dice in the pool with Nightmare dice. The character must have three non-Nightmare dice in the pool to gain this benefit. Doing so does not increase the character's Nightmare pool past that one roll (unless the player rolls some 10s, of course).

Nightmare dice function like normal dice for the roll, except that when the player rolls a 10 on a Nightmare die, she immediately adds another point to the character's Nightmare pool. The character can accumulate multiple Nightmare points during a single roll, but the Nightmare rating never exceeds 10.

Imbalance

When a character's Nightmare rating reaches 10, the player removes all the Nightmare points from the character sheet and then marks an imbalance by circling the character's rightmost Willpower box (underneath the last dot of Willpower, reading left to right). The Willpower point represented by that box functions normally, except that the character suffers a Bedlam Threshold (p. 294) if she spends the Imbalanced point of Willpower. If all of a character's Willpower becomes Imbalanced, she is lost to Bedlam. Marking an Imbalanced Willpower also regains one point of Glamour.

Combat

For lucky changelings, life is largely filled with wonder, magic, and joy. However, the Dauntain try to destroy their magic, and the monstrous Thallain regularly attempt to spread destruction and suffering in their wake. To defeat these foes, or sometimes simply to regain their honor when one of their fellows has wronged them, the Kithain must fight.

In **Changeling: The Dreaming**, combat is designed to be dramatic and exciting, while not downplaying the fact that the characters' lives may be at stake. However, it's also important to remember that combat, like all other aspects of a **Changeling** campaign, should be fun, which means that sometimes enforcing detailed rules and looking up tables needs to take a backseat to keeping the action moving and allowing characters to perform daring and heroic feats. Arguing over rules or spending 10 minutes flipping through this book in the middle of a combat

is going to seriously detract from what might otherwise be an awesome action scene where the characters risk their lives for their allies or beliefs and show exactly how skilled and brave they are. The following rules are here to help everyone have fun, but always keep in mind that the fun is more important than the rules.

Combat is divided into *action turns*, which are three seconds long and have four phases — Initiative, Attack, Defense, and Resolution. First, everyone involved rolls initiative to see who acts when. Then, everyone makes an attack to see whose attack hits and who gets hit. Next, anyone who wishes to makes a defense roll to try to avoid getting hit. Finally, everyone rolls soak and damage to see how badly everyone who was hit was hurt. While every combat scene is different, combat can be broken down into two major types:

Close Combat: This covers both unarmed combat (Dexterity + Brawl) using fists, claws, or kicks, and combat involving weapons (Dexterity + Melee), which includes everything from members of the sidhe jousting on horseback for honor and glory, to a troll bashing one of the Autumn People over the head with a lead pipe. Characters must be within a yard/meter or at most two from each other to engage in any form of close combat.

Ranged Combat: This form of combat requires ranged weapons, which includes elegantly made longbows, shotguns (both use Dexterity + Firearms), and thrown rocks (Dexterity + Athletics). Opponents typically must be able to see one another and be no further apart than their weapon's maximum range to engage in ranged combat.

Phase One: Initiative

Regardless of what action a character takes in combat, when it happens often matters. Can a pooka dive behind a parked car before an angry sidhe fires her bow? Can a heroic troll stab one of the Dark-kin with his spear before it unleashes a monstrous attack on his friend?

The first step in this phase is for both the players and the Storyteller to determine the initiative of every character involved in the combat scene. Roll one die for each character in the scene and add the character's *initiative rating* (equal to Dexterity + Wits). The higher a character's initiative, the earlier they can act in a particular action turn. The character with the highest initiative acts first and the character with the lowest initiative acts last. If two characters have the same initiative roll, then the one with the highest initiative rating goes first. If these characters also have the same initiative rating, then they act simultaneously. A Storyteller who either has lots of her characters involved in a scene or who simply doesn't want to keep track of different initiatives is free to make a single initiative roll for all of her characters. Storytellers and players who wish to further emphasize characters' abilities and to downplay random chance can instead calculate initiative as 6 + Dexterity + Wits for all characters.

During this phase, everyone must also state what their character is doing in this turn, going from the player with the lowest initiative to the player with the highest. This process